

Introduction to Logic I

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Abstract

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Contents

1	Course information	1
2	Lecture notes	1
2.1	03.09.2026	1
2.1.1	Propositional formulas	1
2.1.2	Subformulas	2
2.1.3	Structural induction	2
2.2	07.09.2026	3
2.2.1	Structural induction	3
2.2.2	Closures	3
2.2.3	Semantics of propositional logic	4

1 Course information

The official course information is available on the University of Helsinki course page.

2 Lecture notes

2.1 03.09.2026

2.1.1 Propositional formulas

Definition 2.1. The set of *propositional formulas* is defined inductively as follows:

1. Every propositional symbol p_n , where $n \in \mathbb{N}$, is a propositional formula.
2. If A and B are propositional formulas, then

$$\neg A, \quad (A \wedge B), \quad (A \vee B), \quad (A \rightarrow B), \quad (A \leftrightarrow B)$$

are propositional formulas.

3. No other strings are propositional formulas.

2.1.2 Subformulas

Definition 2.2 (Immediate subformulas). The immediate subformulas of a propositional formula are defined by its outermost connective:

1. A propositional symbol p_n has no immediate subformulas.
2. The only immediate subformula of $\neg A$ is A .
3. The immediate subformulas of $(A \circ B)$ are A and B , where

$$\circ \in \{\wedge, \vee, \rightarrow, \leftrightarrow\}.$$

Definition 2.3 (Subformulas). A formula B is a *subformula* of a formula A if $B = A$, or if there are formulas

$$A = A_0, A_1, \dots, A_k = B$$

such that $k \geq 1$ and A_{i+1} is an immediate subformula of A_i for every $0 \leq i < k$.

2.1.3 Structural induction

Theorem 2.4 (Structural induction). *Let $P(A)$ be a statement about propositional formulas. Suppose that*

1. $P(p_n)$ holds for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$;
2. if $P(A)$ holds, then $P(\neg A)$ holds; and
3. if $P(A)$ and $P(B)$ hold, then $P((A \circ B))$ holds for every

$$\circ \in \{\wedge, \vee, \rightarrow, \leftrightarrow\}.$$

Then $P(A)$ holds for every propositional formula A .

Example 2.5 (Structural induction). For a formula A , let $v(A)$ be the number of occurrences of propositional symbols in A , and let $b(A)$ be the number of occurrences of binary connectives in A . We prove that

$$v(A) = b(A) + 1$$

for every propositional formula A .

If $A = p_n$, then $v(A) = 1$ and $b(A) = 0$, so the claim holds. Suppose next that the claim holds for a formula A . Negation introduces neither a propositional symbol nor a binary connective, and hence

$$v(\neg A) = v(A) = b(A) + 1 = b(\neg A) + 1.$$

Finally, suppose that the claim holds for formulas A and B , and let $\circ$ be any binary connective. Then

$$\begin{aligned} v((A \circ B)) &= v(A) + v(B) \\ &= (b(A) + 1) + (b(B) + 1) \\ &= b((A \circ B)) + 1. \end{aligned}$$

The result follows by structural induction. □

2.2 07.09.2026

2.2.1 Structural induction

Example 2.6 (Matching parentheses). For a propositional formula A , let $l(A)$ and $r(A)$ denote the numbers of occurrences of left and right parentheses in A , respectively. We prove by structural induction that

$$l(A) = r(A)$$

for every propositional formula A .

If $A = p_n$, then $l(A) = 0 = r(A)$. Suppose next that the claim holds for a formula A . Negation introduces no parentheses, so

$$l(\neg A) = l(A) = r(A) = r(\neg A).$$

Finally, suppose that the claim holds for formulas A and B , and let $\circ$ be any binary connective. The formula $(A \circ B)$ introduces one left and one right parenthesis. Hence

$$\begin{aligned} l((A \circ B)) &= l(A) + l(B) + 1 \\ &= r(A) + r(B) + 1 \\ &= r((A \circ B)). \end{aligned}$$

The result follows by structural induction. □

2.2.2 Closures

Definition 2.7 (Closure). Let X be a set, let $B \subseteq X$, and, for $1 \leq i \leq k$, let

$$f_i: X^{n_i} \longrightarrow X$$

be a function. A subset $Y \subseteq X$ is *closed under f_i* if

$$f_i(y_1, \dots, y_{n_i}) \in Y$$

whenever $y_1, \dots, y_{n_i} \in Y$. The *closure of B under $f_1, \dots, f_k$* , denoted by

$$\text{cl}(B; f_1, \dots, f_k),$$

is the smallest subset of X that contains B and is closed under every f_i .

Equivalently, the closure can be written as the intersection

$$\text{cl}(B; f_1, \dots, f_k) = \bigcap \{Y \subseteq X : B \subseteq Y \text{ and } Y \text{ is closed under every } f_i\}.$$

Example 2.8. Let $X = \mathbb{Z}$, $B = \{1\}$, and define functions $f, g: \mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ by

$$f(x) = x + 1 \quad \text{and} \quad g(x) = -x.$$

Then

$$\text{cl}(\{1\}; f, g) = \mathbb{Z}.$$

Indeed, every subset of $\mathbb{Z}$ that contains 1 and is closed under g must also contain -1 . Closure under f then gives 0, and repeated applications of f give every positive integer. Applying g to these integers gives every negative integer. Thus any such closed set is all of $\mathbb{Z}$, while $\mathbb{Z}$ itself clearly contains 1 and is closed under both functions.

Corollary 2.9 (Induction on a closure). *Set*

$$C = \text{cl}(B; f_1, \dots, f_k).$$

To prove that every element of C satisfies a property P , it suffices to prove that

- 1. every element of B satisfies P ; and*
- 2. for each i , if $x_1, \dots, x_{n_i}$ satisfy P , then $f_i(x_1, \dots, x_{n_i})$ also satisfies P .*

Proof. Let Y be the set of all elements of $\text{cl}(B; f_1, \dots, f_k)$ that satisfy P . The two assumptions imply that $B \subseteq Y$ and that Y is closed under every f_i . Since the closure is the smallest such set,

$$\text{cl}(B; f_1, \dots, f_k) \subseteq Y.$$

Hence every element of the closure satisfies P . □

Let Σ be the alphabet of propositional logic, let Σ^* be the set of all finite strings over Σ , and let

$$V = \{p_n : n \in \mathbb{N}\}$$

be the set of propositional symbols. The logical connectives determine the following functions on strings:

$$f_{\neg}(A) = \neg A$$

and

$$f_{\circ}(A, B) = (A \circ B), \quad \circ \in \{\wedge, \vee, \rightarrow, \leftrightarrow\}.$$

The set of propositional formulas is precisely

$$\text{cl}(V; f_{\neg}, f_{\wedge}, f_{\vee}, f_{\rightarrow}, f_{\leftrightarrow}).$$

In particular, if $S \subseteq \Sigma^*$ contains every propositional symbol and is closed under all functions associated with the logical connectives, then S contains every propositional formula.

2.2.3 Semantics of propositional logic

Definition 2.10 (Truth assignment). A *truth assignment* is a function

$$v: V \longrightarrow \{0, 1\},$$

where V is the set of propositional symbols. The values 0 and 1 represent **false** and **true**, respectively.

The truth values of the logical connectives are defined as follows.

Definition 2.11 (Negation). The negation $\neg A$ is true exactly when A is false.

A	$\neg A$
0	1
1	0

Definition 2.12 (Conjunction). The conjunction $(A \wedge B)$ is true exactly when both A and B are true.

A	B	$(A \wedge B)$
0	0	0
0	1	0
1	0	0
1	1	1

Definition 2.13 (Disjunction). The disjunction $(A \vee B)$ is true exactly when at least one of A and B is true.

A	B	$(A \vee B)$
0	0	0
0	1	1
1	0	1
1	1	1

Definition 2.14 (Implication). The implication $(A \rightarrow B)$ is false exactly when A is true and B is false. It is important to note that implication is **not** symmetric.

A	B	$(A \rightarrow B)$
0	0	1
0	1	1
1	0	0
1	1	1

Definition 2.15 (Equivalence). The equivalence $(A \leftrightarrow B)$ is true exactly when A and B have the same truth value.

A	B	$(A \leftrightarrow B)$
0	0	1
0	1	0
1	0	0
1	1	1

Definition 2.16 (Truth value). Let A be a propositional formula and let v be a truth assignment. The *truth value* $v(A)$ of A is defined by the following rules:

1. If A is a propositional symbol p_n , then $v(A)$ is already defined.
2. If $A = \neg B$ and $v(B)$ is defined, then

$$v(A) = \begin{cases} 0, & \text{if } v(B) = 1, \\ 1, & \text{if } v(B) = 0. \end{cases}$$

Another way to write this is $v(A) = 1 - v(B)$.

3. If $A = (B \wedge C)$ and $v(B)$ and $v(C)$ are defined, then $v(A) = 1$ exactly when $v(B) = v(C) = 1$, and $v(A) = 0$ otherwise. Another way to write this is $v(A)v(B)$.

4. If $A = (B \vee C)$ and $v(B)$ and $v(C)$ are defined, then $v(A) = 1$ when at least one of $v(B) = 1$ and $v(C) = 1$ holds, and $v(A) = 0$ when $v(B) = v(C) = 0$.
5. If $A = (B \rightarrow C)$ and $v(B)$ and $v(C)$ are defined, then $v(A) = 0$ when $v(B) = 1$ and $v(C) = 0$, and $v(A) = 1$ in all other cases.
6. If $A = (B \leftrightarrow C)$ and $v(B)$ and $v(C)$ are defined, then $v(A) = 1$ iff $v(B) = v(C)$.

Definition 2.17 (Classification of propositional formulas). A propositional formula A is

1. a *tautology* if $v(A) = 1$ for every truth assignment v ;
2. a *contradiction* if $v(A) = 0$ for every truth assignment v ;
3. *contingent* if there are truth assignments v and w such that $v(A) = 1$ and $w(A) = 0$;
4. *satisfiable* if $v(A) = 1$ for at least one truth assignment v ; and
5. *falsifiable* if $v(A) = 0$ for at least one truth assignment v .

Example 2.18 (De Morgan's laws). Consider the formulas

$$(\neg(A \wedge B) \leftrightarrow (\neg A \vee \neg B)) \quad \text{and} \quad (\neg(A \vee B) \leftrightarrow (\neg A \wedge \neg B)).$$

Their truth values can be compared using the following table:

A	B	$\neg(A \wedge B)$	$(\neg A \vee \neg B)$	$\neg(A \vee B)$	$(\neg A \wedge \neg B)$
0	0	1	1	1	1
0	1	1	1	0	0
1	0	1	1	0	0
1	1	0	0	0	0

The two sides of each equivalence have the same truth value under every truth assignment. Consequently, both equivalences are tautologies. These equivalences are known as *De Morgan's laws*.